the proceedings, would have become my wife. I was starting to think that finding the right words to describe what I really felt might just have to wait for a glass of champagne and the spur of the moment. I rang Peregrine:

‘Sorry, Peregrine. My speech. I’m still not sure I’m saying what I want to. Or if I’m saying it the right way.’

He was still awake or, at least, pretended he was:

‘No problem. I’ll be right up.’

Five minutes later, I was standing at the end of my bed and Peregrine had pulled a chair up in front of me:

‘Go on, then. Let me hear it and I can give you a few pointers. I’ll be the audience.’

I was a bit embarrassed but he assured me I would be on the day too, so this was good practice. Almost as soon as I started, he was clearing his throat loudly and coughing. As I ploughed on, he started throwing in comments like:

‘That’s not very funny.’

He started rattling his chair: anything, really, to try to throw me out of my stride. He knew the speech was going to be all right: we changed a couple of things but I didn’t even use my script on the day. He was just trying to give me an idea of how standing up there, doing it in front of an audience, might feel. By the time Peregrine had finished giving me a hard time, I was ready for bed. At least I’d had some help. The Best Man, Gary Neville, had had to sweat through it all on his own.

The next morning, I was pacing about in the corridor getting myself nervous about what lay ahead. I found myself outside Gary’s room and I could hear talking. He couldn’t be on the phone: there wasn’t one in the room. The stone walls of the castle meant he’d be lucky to get decent reception on his cell phone. I couldn’t help wondering what he was up to. I opened the door as quietly as I could. Gary was standing there in front of the mirror, holding a can of deodorant in front of his face like a microphone, practicing his speech. I knew how he was feeling, of course, after the time I’d had the night before. But I burst out laughing anyway. Gary did too. It was going to be a big day all round. I realized how seriously he was taking it when the manicurist arrived. And I was honored: Gaz had waited for my wedding day to get his nails done for the first time in his life.